4.4 Drafting the Declaration

Every Fourth of July, the air fills with the sound of marching bands and the night sky with fireworks—all to celebrate a piece of paper? It's not just any piece of paper. It's the document that launched a new country and gave a name and an identity to the United States of America.

MAIN IDEA In 1776, the Continental Congress formally declared the independence of the United States of America from Great Britain.

MOVING TOWARD INDEPENDENCE

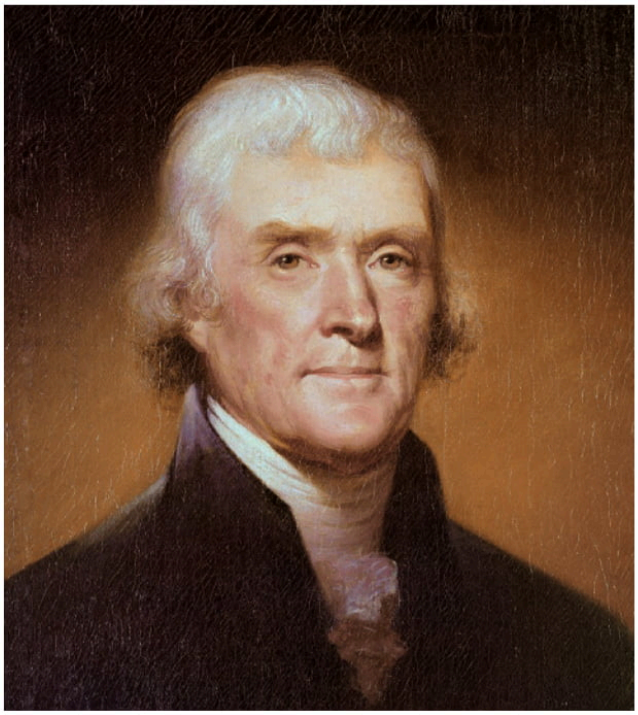
By the spring of 1776, the Continental Congress was making decisions for the colonies as a whole, serving in effect as the colonial government. In this role, the Congress declared that American ports would accept ships from any country—except, however, for Great Britain. The Congress also encouraged the colonies to establish their own independent governments.

Then, on June 7, Richard Henry Lee of Virginia placed a shocking resolution before the delegates. It stated that "these United Colonies are, and of right ought to be, free and independent States."

Not all the delegates were in favor of Lee's resolution to separate completely from Britain. Still, the Congress appointed a committee to draft an official statement to declare independence. **Thomas Jefferson** of Virginia, a brilliant scholar and persuasive writer, would be the principal author.

John Adams and Benjamin Franklin were also on the committee to create the document. Franklin had lived in England for several years, serving as a representative from several colonies to the British government. Adams suggested that Jefferson should write the first draft. Franklin gave Jefferson advice and helped revise the document.

On July 2, 1776, the Continental Congress voted to approve independence from Britain. Two days later, the Congress adopted Jefferson's document, the **Declaration of Independence**.



Thomas Jefferson
In addition to drafting the Declaration of Independence, Jefferson served his country for more than 50 years as a historian, public official, president, and founder of the University of Virginia. His famous words captured the voice and identity of a new America like no one else's could.

SELF-EVIDENT TRUTHS

Many of the ideas expressed in the Declaration of Independence can be traced to John Locke. The first part states, "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty, and the Pursuit of Happiness." An **unalienable right** is one that cannot be taken away.

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National Archives Washington, D.C.

Visitors to Washington, D.C., can stop by the Rotunda of the National Archives Building to see the original Declaration of Independence, safely encased in bulletproof glass and under the watchful eye of armed guards. You can read the Declaration in its entirety in the Citizenship Handbook.

Yet the unalienable rights of two large groups were not discussed in the Declaration. In his first draft, Jefferson had listed slavery as one of the king's offenses. After an intense debate, this section was removed. The Declaration was silent on the rights of women, too, even though John Adams's wife, Abigail, had pleaded with him in a letter to "remember the ladies and be more generous and favorable to them than your ancestors."

The second part of the Declaration listed the offenses of the king against the colonies. These included refusing to approve laws passed by the colonial assemblies, placing a standing army in the colonies, and imposing taxes without colonial consent. For these reasons and more, the Continental Congress declared the 13 colonies "free and independent states," the United States of America.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What are the principal parts of the Declaration of Independence?
2. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** What is an "unalienable right," and how did the inclusion of these words in the Declaration point to a new philosophy of governing?
3. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** What laws did Jefferson refer to when he listed the complaints against the British king?

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